

1.1.4 New Opportunities

The new subject criteria, published by QCA in December 2002, are intended to make mathematics more accessible for students and easier for schools and colleges to deliver within existing time constraints. This specification is designed to take full advantage of the opportunities this opens up.

The content of the subject core is little changed but it is now spread over four units, two at AS and two at A2, instead of the previous three. This means that the content of each individual Pure Mathematics unit is reduced so that more time can be given to teaching the topics within it.

A particular feature of this specification is the first Pure Mathematics unit, *C1*. It is designed to give students a firm foundation in the basic skills that they will need for all their other units, thereby making advanced study of mathematics accessible to many more people.

Another major new opportunity occurs with Further Mathematics. It is now, for the first time, possible to obtain AS Further Mathematics on three AS units. In this specification, the first Pure Mathematics unit, *FP1*, is a genuine AS unit and students who have been successful at Higher Tier GCSE should be able to start studying it at the same time as *C1* and *C2*. It will no longer be necessary for potential Further Mathematics students to mark time while they learn enough of the single Mathematics to allow them to get started.

It is however still possible for schools and colleges to deliver Further Mathematics in other ways: for example by doing three extra units over the two years for the AS qualification. That point illustrates another feature of this specification, its flexibility. It is designed to meet the needs of a wide range of students, from those who find AS Level a real challenge to others who are blessed with extraordinary talent in mathematics. The flexibility also covers the needs of schools and colleges with widely differing numbers of post-16 mathematics students.